ENGLISH C1 · ADVANCED GRAMMAR

Advanced probability and modality

Calibrate probability with may well, would seem, be bound to, be likely to and related modal expressions. The lesson connects form, meaning, register and real editorial decisions rather than treating the pattern as an isolated rule.

THE CENTRAL IDEA

Use advanced probability and modality to match the strength of a prediction or inference to the quality of evidence while preserving the intended meaning and register.

Calibrate probability with may well, would seem, be bound to, be likely to and related modal expressions.

MODEL

The revised policy may well reduce short-term demand.

modal/stance phrase + proposition + evidence boundary

6 GUIDED STAGES · 30 LEARNING DECISIONS

This complete guide combines explanation, visual reasoning, practice and feedback. Separate exercise and answer-key editions are also available from the lesson page.

LEARNING OUTCOMES

OUTCOME 1

01

Recognise the main advanced probability and modality patterns in authentic contexts.

OUTCOME 2

02

Choose a form that accurately expresses match the strength of a prediction or inference to the quality of evidence.

OUTCOME 3

03

Avoid errors that change time, agency, emphasis or speaker commitment.

OUTCOME 4

04

Use the structure appropriately in analysis, forecasting, academic argument and professional advice.

Build meaning before form

Calibrate probability with may well, would seem, be bound to, be likely to and related modal expressions.

What advanced probability and modality communicates

Calibrate probability with may well, would seem, be bound to, be likely to and related modal expressions.

The central purpose is to match the strength of a prediction or inference to the quality of evidence. A successful choice therefore preserves the proposition while making the intended relationship, viewpoint or degree of commitment visible to the reader.

The revised policy may well reduce short-term demand.	a possibility considered reasonably well supported
The discrepancy would seem to result from a coding error.	a cautious conclusion presented with analytical distance
A delay of this length is bound to affect costs.	an outcome presented as virtually inevitable

How the pattern is built

Use this working formula: modal/stance phrase + proposition + evidence boundary. The formula is a decision path: it identifies the trigger, the clause architecture and the element that carries tense or modality.

The model “The revised policy may well reduce short-term demand.” shows the complete pattern in context. Rebuild the sentence from meaning to form instead of translating each word independently.

Choice	Structure	Example
Supported possibility	may well + base verb	The revised policy may well reduce short-term demand.
Distanced inference	would seem to + infinitive	The discrepancy would seem to result from a coding error.
Strong expectation	be bound to + infinitive	A delay of this length is bound to affect costs.

Choose by meaning, not by surface similarity

Neighbouring structures may contain similar words but perform different jobs. Compare the three reference patterns and name the intended effect before completing the sentence.

A reliable answer explains both why the chosen form works and why a plausible alternative would change the meaning, time relation, information focus or level of certainty.

Meaning	Best route
a possibility considered reasonably well supported	Supported possibility
a cautious conclusion presented with analytical distance	Distanced inference
an outcome presented as virtually inevitable	Strong expectation

Register, discourse and editorial control

This grammar is especially useful in analysis, forecasting, academic argument and professional advice. Its value comes from helping the reader process a relationship efficiently, not from making the sentence sound artificially complex.

After editing, check recoverability, natural word order and consistency with the surrounding paragraph. If the marked structure creates ambiguity, return to a fuller or more neutral clause.

Reason through the pattern

The visual map moves from communicative purpose to structural trigger, then to the final clause. It keeps meaning and form visible at the same time so the learner can justify every choice.

01	02	03
modal/stance phrase	proposition	evidence boundary

DECIDE IN THIS ORDER

STEP 1

Decision 1

Identify the communicative purpose before selecting a form: match the strength of a prediction or inference to the quality of evidence.

STEP 2

Decision 2

Locate the structural trigger and match it to one of the reference patterns.

STEP 3

Decision 3

Check time reference, clause relationships, agency and speaker commitment.

STEP 4

Decision 4

Read the complete sentence in context and confirm that its register suits analysis, forecasting, academic argument and professional advice.

STEP 5

Decision 5

Compare the result with a neutral alternative and keep the marked form only when it adds useful meaning.

Compare forms and meanings

Use the table to justify each structural choice.

Pattern	Form	Model
Supported possibility	may well + base verb	The revised policy may well reduce short-term demand.
Distanced inference	would seem to + infinitive	The discrepancy would seem to result from a coding error.
Strong expectation	be bound to + infinitive	A delay of this length is bound to affect costs.

EXAMPLES AT A GLANCE

The revised policy may well reduce short-term demand.	a possibility considered reasonably well supported
The discrepancy would seem to result from a coding error.	a cautious conclusion presented with analytical distance
A delay of this length is bound to affect costs.	an outcome presented as virtually inevitable

COMMON ERRORS

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not interpret may well as permission.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not stack would seem with a contradictory certainty marker.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not use bound to when substantial uncertainty remains.

Recognition in context

Choose the sentence whose grammar matches the stated communicative purpose.

A1 · MEANING DECISION 1

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: a possibility considered reasonably well supported?

OPTIONS The revised policy may well reduce short-term demand. · The discrepancy would seem to result from a coding error. · A delay of this length is bound to affect costs.

A2 · MEANING DECISION 2

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: a cautious conclusion presented with analytical distance?

OPTIONS The discrepancy would seem to result from a coding error. · A delay of this length is bound to affect costs. · The revised policy may well reduce short-term demand.

A3 · MEANING DECISION 3

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: an outcome presented as virtually inevitable?

OPTIONS A delay of this length is bound to affect costs. · The revised policy may well reduce short-term demand. · The discrepancy would seem to result from a coding error.

A4 · INTERPRETATION 4

What does “The revised policy may well reduce short-term demand.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS a possibility considered reasonably well supported · a cautious conclusion presented with analytical distance · an outcome presented as virtually inevitable

A5 · INTERPRETATION 5

What does “The discrepancy would seem to result from a coding error.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS a cautious conclusion presented with analytical distance · an outcome presented as virtually inevitable · a possibility considered reasonably well supported

A6 · INTERPRETATION 6

What does “A delay of this length is bound to affect costs.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS an outcome presented as virtually inevitable · a possibility considered reasonably well supported · a cautious conclusion presented with analytical distance

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Form and function

Identify both the structural family and the meaning carried by each model.

B1 · FORM AND FUNCTION 1

"The revised policy may well reduce short-term demand." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Supported possibility / Distanced inference / Strong expectation · Gap 2: a possibility considered reasonably well supported / a cautious conclusion presented with analytical distance / an outcome presented as virtually inevitable

B2 · FORM AND FUNCTION 2

"The discrepancy would seem to result from a coding error." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Distanced inference / Strong expectation / Supported possibility · Gap 2: a cautious conclusion presented with analytical distance / an outcome presented as virtually inevitable / a possibility considered reasonably well supported

B3 · FORM AND FUNCTION 3

"A delay of this length is bound to affect costs." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Strong expectation / Supported possibility / Distanced inference · Gap 2: an outcome presented as virtually inevitable / a possibility considered reasonably well supported / a cautious conclusion presented with analytical distance

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Guided discourse choices

Maintain accurate form and meaning across a connected sequence of decisions.

C1 · EDITORIAL PLANNING

Choose the model that expresses a possibility considered reasonably well supported: _____. Choose the model that expresses a cautious conclusion presented with analytical distance: _____. Choose the model that expresses an outcome presented as virtually inevitable: _____. Choose the model built with may well + base verb: _____. Choose the model built with would seem to + infinitive: _____. Choose the model built with be bound to + infinitive: _____.

_____
_____

WORD BANK

Available forms

A delay of this length is bound to affect costs. · The discrepancy would seem to result from a coding error. · The revised policy may well reduce short-term demand.

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Open reconstruction

Recover the missing structural trigger without a word bank.

D1 · INDEPENDENT RECONSTRUCTION

The revised policy _____ short-term demand. The discrepancy _____ from a coding error. A delay of this length _____ costs. State the full structural pattern for Supported possibility: _____. State the full structural pattern for Distanced inference: _____.

_____
_____
_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Controlled transformation

Rewrite the neutral source so that it performs the requested advanced function.

E1 · TRANSFORMATION 1

Rewrite “The policy might reduce demand, and the evidence makes that plausible.” using the Supported possibility pattern to express a possibility considered reasonably well supported.

_____
_____

E2 · TRANSFORMATION 2

Rewrite “The evidence suggests a coding error.” using the Distanced inference pattern to express a cautious conclusion presented with analytical distance.

_____
_____

E3 · TRANSFORMATION 3

Rewrite “The delay will almost certainly affect costs.” using the Strong expectation pattern to express an outcome presented as virtually inevitable.

_____
_____

E4 · TRANSFORMATION 4

Rewrite “The policy might reduce demand, and the evidence makes that plausible.” using the Supported possibility pattern to express a possibility considered reasonably well supported.

_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Communicative production

Use the grammar independently in realistic academic, professional and conversational contexts.

F1 · PRODUCTION TASK 1

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Supported possibility to express a possibility considered reasonably well supported, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F2 · PRODUCTION TASK 2

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Distanced inference to express a cautious conclusion presented with analytical distance, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F3 · PRODUCTION TASK 3

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Strong expectation to express an outcome presented as virtually inevitable, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

Final self-check

Complete these prompts without reopening the guide.

R1 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: communicative purpose.

_____
_____
_____

R2 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: structural trigger.

_____
_____
_____

R3 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: meaning contrast.

_____
_____
_____

R4 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: register choice.

_____
_____
_____

Recognition in context

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

A1

The revised policy may well reduce short-term demand.

Supported possibility is the best match because a possibility considered reasonably well supported.

A2

The discrepancy would seem to result from a coding error.

Distanced inference is the best match because a cautious conclusion presented with analytical distance.

A3

A delay of this length is bound to affect costs.

Strong expectation is the best match because an outcome presented as virtually inevitable.

A4

a possibility considered reasonably well supported

The Supported possibility pattern communicates a possibility considered reasonably well supported.

A5

a cautious conclusion presented with analytical distance

The Distanced inference pattern communicates a cautious conclusion presented with analytical distance.

A6

an outcome presented as virtually inevitable

The Strong expectation pattern communicates an outcome presented as virtually inevitable.

Form and function

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

B1

Supported possibility / a possibility considered reasonably well supported

The structure belongs to the Supported possibility pattern. Its communicative purpose is a possibility considered reasonably well supported.

B2

Distanced inference / a cautious conclusion presented with analytical distance

The structure belongs to the Distanced inference pattern. Its communicative purpose is a cautious conclusion presented with analytical distance.

B3

Strong expectation / an outcome presented as virtually inevitable

The structure belongs to the Strong expectation pattern. Its communicative purpose is an outcome presented as virtually inevitable.

Guided discourse choices

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

C1

The revised policy may well reduce short-term demand.

Supported possibility: may well + base verb.

C2

The discrepancy would seem to result from a coding error.

Distanced inference: would seem to + infinitive.

C3

A delay of this length is bound to affect costs.

Strong expectation: be bound to + infinitive.

C4

The revised policy may well reduce short-term demand.

Supported possibility: may well + base verb.

C5

The discrepancy would seem to result from a coding error.

Distanced inference: would seem to + infinitive.

C6

A delay of this length is bound to affect costs.

Strong expectation: be bound to + infinitive.

Open reconstruction

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

D1

may well reduce

Supported possibility requires “may well reduce” in this model. may well + base verb.

D2

would seem to result

Distanced inference requires “would seem to result” in this model. would seem to + infinitive.

D3

is bound to affect

Strong expectation requires “is bound to affect” in this model. be bound to + infinitive.

D4

may well + base verb

Supported possibility is built as may well + base verb.

D5

would seem to + infinitive

Distanced inference is built as would seem to + infinitive.

Controlled transformation

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

E1

The revised policy may well reduce short-term demand.

may well + base verb. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended supported possibility effect.

E2

The discrepancy would seem to result from a coding error.

would seem to + infinitive. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended distanced inference effect.

E3

A delay of this length is bound to affect costs.

be bound to + infinitive. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended strong expectation effect.

E4

The revised policy may well reduce short-term demand.

may well + base verb. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended supported possibility effect.

Communicative production

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

F1

The revised policy may well reduce short-term demand. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses may well + base verb accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F2

The discrepancy would seem to result from a coding error. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses would seem to + infinitive accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F3

A delay of this length is bound to affect costs. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses be bound to + infinitive accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

Diagnose the pattern, not only the score

Use this page to decide what to revisit in the complete guide.

CHECK · TRIGGER OR CONTEXT

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · AUXILIARY OR STRUCTURAL CHOICE

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MAIN VERB OR CLAUSE FORM

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MEANING AND REGISTER

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____